

“ THANK YOU APOLLO 8. YOU SAVED 1968. ”

Anonymous telegram received by Frank Borman, after the success of the Apollo 8 mission

to its knees. It began as a series of student protests that broke out at universities in Paris, following confrontations with administrators and police. Further police action inflamed the situation, leading to a **general strike** by over 10 million workers across France—roughly two-thirds of the workforce. The government came close to collapse; President Charles de Gaulle (1890–1970)

Protest in Paris

When French strikers took to the streets in May, the country was on the verge of revolution. The largest rallies were held in Paris.

called for new parliamentary elections on June 23. Although De Gaulle won the election, the Paris riots were regarded as a **cultural and social revolution**.

Troops from five **Warsaw Pact countries** (see 1955) stormed into **Czechoslovakia** on August 20 to seize control and restore communism to the country. During an eight-month period that became known as the **Prague Spring**, the incumbent prime minister Alexander Dubcek had made **substantial reforms**, including freedom of speech. He was arrested, and his government replaced with

a **repressive regime** (see 1989). The invasion drew condemnation from around the world. Jan Palach, a Czech student, **burned himself to death** in protest over the Soviet occupation. An estimated 500,000 gathered to watch his funeral procession.

On September 7, a prominent gathering of women disrupted the staging of **Miss America**, a long-standing **beauty pageant** held at Atlantic City's convention hall. The protest was organized by the **New York Radical Women** (NYRW), a group active in the civil rights and antiwar movements. They attacked the pageant's

beauty standards as racist—no black woman had ever made it to the final. The demonstrators brandished signs that read “**Women's Liberation**,” and threw bras into bins as a sign of protest, which began the myth that feminists “burn their bras.”

Americans, finally, had cause to rejoice at the end of the year when **Apollo 8**, the first manned craft to **orbit the moon**, was launched into space on December 21. Live pictures of the lunar surface were beamed back to Earth. The crew, Frank Borman, James Lovell, and William Anders, returned on December 27 as **national heroes**.

150

WOMEN
PROTESTERS

52

BEAUTY
CONTESTANTS

Beauty and backlash

The glamorous contestants appearing in the **Miss America Pageant**, in Atlanta, were outnumbered three to one by the protesters.



June 6 Death of Robert Kennedy (b. 1925)

June 8 James Earl Ray, who murdered Martin Luther King, Jr., is arrested in London

June 30 Charles De Gaulle's landslide win in French election

August 20 Warsaw Pact troops invade Czechoslovakia

September 7 New York Radical Women (NYRW) protests outside Miss America

October 18 Bob Beamon sets world record in long jump

November 6 Richard Nixon wins US presidential election

December 2 Nixon names Henry Kissinger as National Security Advisor

December 21 Apollo 8 is launched

June 7 Sirhan charged with murder of Robert Kennedy

July 13 Outbreak of flu pandemic in Hong Kong

August 28 Basil D'Oliveira, a black cricketer, dropped from England's cricket tour of South Africa

October 12 Summer Olympic Games in Mexico start

November 1 President Johnson orders bombing to stop in Vietnam

November 28 Death of British author E. M. Forster (b. 1897)

December 20 Death of US author John Steinbeck (b. 1902)

December 27 Apollo 8 returns to Earth